STRATEGY DEVELOPMENT & DELIVERY:

BUILDING A CHANGE-READY CULTURE

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1. Introduction

Over the past 12 months I have been working with several higher and further education institutions involved in both developing and delivering a new, or refreshed, strategy. Among questions the groups have been grappling with, two have come to the fore:

- *"What are the most important factors that need attention to create and successfully implement a strategy in my organisation?" and*
- *"How do I build a more change-ready culture as part of my implementation plan?"*

To answer both questions many different issues need to be considered, no single blueprint exists. History, current circumstances and the external environment all play a role in deciding what factors to prioritise. As a basis for further exploration, I offered to map out some of the factors which in my experience were likely contributors to success. These are summarised within 'Some Keys to Success' in the figure below and explored further in section 2.

As you will also see, one of the factors I highlight (05) is the topic of '*… high cultural readiness for change'.* I unpack this in more detail in section 3, along with some of the issues for consideration. By taking action in these areas, leaders will find it easier to make progress with ensuring that there is cultural readiness for change. But first, let's briefly explore the components for successful strategy development and delivery.

2. Ensuring Successful Strategy Development & Delivery

Let's briefly examine each of these dimensions including some of the more common potential pitfalls.

2.1 Guided by a clear, inspiring and collectively owned destination of choice

Simple? Not quite. Each part alone is difficult enough. All four parts together demand real hard thinking - and yet when achieved are an important contributor towards success. The most common pitfalls I come across are evidenced by only satisfying two or three of these criteria. For example, I have seen clear articulation of a destination of choice (tick) but without collective ownership or believing collective ownership only relates to some stakeholders. A second pitfall I have seen is describing the destination of choice as a number (e.g. a league table aspiration). Ask yourself: "when were you last inspired by such nonsense? Sure, celebrate when you get somewhere but don't be fooled into believing anyone in your university or college is delivering their contributions by constantly imagining *'one day we'll be in the top … '(*pick your fantasy number).

2.2 Informed & credible - transformative with a high likelihood of success

Delivering point 1 provides some assurance of success but it is of course not sufficient. This second factor is the first of two "stress tests" of factor 1. Inspiring, collectively owned and clearly communicated is good. But is it credible (enough) whilst also setting out a high level of ambition? In addition, do a further sense-check, what is the likelihood of achieving your objective? If it's way beyond your capacity and resources, you should reflect on whether you are setting you organisation up for failure. On the other hand, if it is beyond reach at present but you have identified ways in which to extend your capacity and resources, then keep going.

2.3 Built on well informed horizon scanning evidence to inform choices & decisions

The third factor involves a further stress test for an emerging clear, inspiring, credible and transformative strategy by ensuring it is well informed by an understanding of future horizon scanning trends. Too often this factor is assumed to have been undertaken rather than it being seen as a structured and integral part of the strategy development process. It also needs to be undertaken through two lenses. First, by understanding the future from the perspective of the present day and second by looking back from the perspective of few potential futures. This latter approach is enhanced by some scenario-based stress testing. How resilient are your ambitions and choices when viewed through the lens of the futures you may face?

2.4 Aligned, integrated & focused - not a laundry list of activities

This fourth criteria is the first of three further factors which come into sharp focus as you start to translate your strategy into delivery. Too easily this can become a set of siloed priorities typically framed around 3 -5 strategic priorities and 5 or more enablers. Each set then forms a separate strand of the strategic plan. Sadly, it can also become a laundry list of ambitions with few if any covering the crucial overlap areas where 2

or more strategic priorities contribute to an issue of importance. Sure, these sometimes get attention but check if you are doing so in a structured manner and in a way which ensures alignment and integration.

2.5 Phased & paced delivery based on capacity, resources & high cultural readiness for change

The latter part of this condition for success is addressed in section 3. The former is also increasingly important. How will you select which strategic priorities you wish to progress in your first phase (6-12 months) and how will you ensure you have adequate capacity (typically people, skills/experience and time) to ensure you can make progress in the crucial early phase of delivering your agenda? Addressing these is often relatively straightforward. What is more challenging is ensuring you have thought through your phase 2 priorities (1-2 years) and beyond. If not, you are in danger of the early engagement (and hopefully excitement) running into the sand as your ambitious agenda loses momentum.

2.6 Performance focused & values based

Our sixth factor is about how you will measure process. This should cover both 'what' you are seeking to achieve as well as 'how' you are going to do so. You might think of this as a combination of the 'classic' Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) with a less common set of Key Behavioural Indicators (KBIs). The former are normally relatively clear - the latter often much less so. Both are, however, essential if you are to ensure you balance an emphasis on being performance focused and values based in your delivery. Too high an emphasis on the former without any reference to the latter might deliver short term results, but if the latter are completely missing you risk the development of an unhealthy, or potentially toxic, culture. Conversely, too great a focus on the latter without regularly reviewing the former can lead to any early warning signs of strategic drift being missed.

2.7 Distributed individual and team-based accountability

Our penultimate factor to assess is how clearly levels of individual and team-based accountability are articulated. The former are relatively straightforward and linked to the role profile/description of senior post holders and through annual objective setting exercises. Of course, it is also vital that these are regularly reviewed and assessed. Are you truly investing enough time in this area and holding your team members accountable?

It is also important to include team accountability. Do you have a clear set of team-based mutual accountabilities by which you and the senior team will be judged? And, if any form of performance-based reward system exists, is team-based performance adequately recognised?

2.8 Agile & adaptable to changing circumstances

My last success factor is the frequency with which the strategy and priorities for delivery are reviewed. At the extreme level this takes place around 12 months before the expiry date of the current strategy. It might be five or 10 years since it was initially drafted and in the fast-changing world of today this is no longer (and indeed was it ever?) adequate. Agile strategy delivery requires a much more frequent and structured review. Some may suggest this implicitly takes place as part of the annual planning round but you might wish to start by making it a much more explicit process.

3. Enhancing Your Cultural Readiness for Change

The field of management and leadership is full of ideas about the concept of 'culture'. Culture as *'the way we do things around here'* highlights its wide-ranging influence on organisations; the often mis-quoted statement *'culture eats strategy for breakfast, lunch and dinner'* (no longer ascribed to Peter Drucker) also emphasises its importance as an underpinning contributor to success. Others suggest *'change readiness is more than the absence of resistance'* to emphasise, to some extent, its links to the underlying values and behaviours which shape the cultural landscape. Others propose certain prerequisites which lead to a successful 'readiness for change culture' including *"change clarity, change commitment, change capacity, change capability and change effectiveness*"[i].

Reflecting on recent and current cases which I have experienced, I identify six potential issues which I believe influence the level of cultural readiness for change and innovation:

3.1 Acknowledge the cultural shadow of the past.

Culture evolves over time and as a new or existing leader, recognising the influence of the past on the organisational readiness for change is an important first step. This is easier if you are new to an organisation – your antennae are attuned to picking up differences from what you have experienced and what you might have expected to be the culture. As an insider you need to work harder – you are in a sense an architect of the current cultural readiness. You may also need some external assistance to independently assess or 'sense check' your perceptions. Whichever is the case, an honest appraisal of the influence of the past is helpful. Ty Wiggins in his reflections on the challenges facing new CEOs refers to this as the influence of 'your ghost'[ii] and the different issues and pitfalls to avoid when following a 'hero' or a 'villain'. In either case you can start to characterise the level of readiness for change.

Through my work in higher education on leadership transitions[iii], when I have come across a low level of cultural readiness for change, it is often associated with circumstances such as:

- A failure of leadership leading to the early exit of a Vice-Chancellor, the former in part associated with a very top-down directive style and a consequent high level of compliance and lack of challenge.

- Few incentives for change and innovation - the performance indicators are largely focussed on the delivery of business as usual within existing 'business units' and do not typically encourage cross-unit innovation and change.
- A culture of upward delegation of decisions rather than one of empowered, calculated risk-taking and experimentation. The lack of the latter is typically associated with the way those who did not seek 'permission' were treated if successful innovation did not appear as quickly as expected.

The first leadership action, therefore, is to start at the top and work to shift the culture and diminish the shadow of the ghost through proactive approaches to new ways of working, more of a learning organisation style[iv] than that which currently exists.

3.2 Increase levels of psychological safety in the culture of the senior team

This second area of focus is essential if you, as the team leader, are going to be able to have a truly open conversation about culture and the ways in which to enhance the readiness of the culture for change and innovation. Psychological safely is a well-known (and used) term in well-run organisations with a strong positive culture. At the very extreme level, when it is absent (think Harrods), it will lead to a toxic, exploitative and dangerous environment. Defining it is relatively straightforward, Adam Grant[v] does so eloquently as follows:

When You Have It	When You Don't
See mistakes as opportunities to learn	See mistakes as threats to your career
Willing to take risks and fail	Unwilling to rock the boat
Speaking your mind in meetings	Keeping your ideas to yourself
Openly sharing your struggles	Only touting your strengths
Trust in your teammates and supervisors	Fear of your teammates and supervisors
Sticking your neck out	Having it chopped off
What would you add?	***What would you add?***

If your organisational diagnosis suggests the senior team is not demonstrating enough of the left-hand column, then start working on building a higher performing team. Point 3 may offer a start point.

3.3 Focus on cultural readiness through the lens of values and lived behaviours

Culture manifests itself largely through the ways in which we experience our many and varied interactions with others. The level of readiness for change is sometimes expressed as a core part of the values which many organisations express as part of their strategic plans. Examples might include values such as:

- Teamwork
- Collaboration
- Engagement
- Accountability

You know the type. Sometimes these values are translated into some form of behavioural charter to articulate expectations and ways of working. Over the years, I've seen some exceptionally detailed work on this involving engagement across the organisation, with one case involving thousands of contributions. A great start! However, after this, five values emerged. How? Well, the senior leader made the final call and announced them. Did they get translated into behaviours. No. Why not? *"Well you can't tell academics how to behave,"* was one explanation I was offered when I asked the question. The reality of embedding some form of cultural readiness through values and behaviours requires serious commitment and a willingness to demonstrate the behaviours in action. As one of my colleagues commented astutely, '*Values need to be lived not laminated'*. Another commentator, Patrick Lencioni, also rightly emphasised, "*If you're not willing to accept the pain real values incur, don't bother going to the trouble of formulating a values statement*[vi].

As a leader seeking to enhance change readiness, a serious examination of the culture through the lens of values and behaviours is an important way to have an impact. If through point 2 the senior team has extended its level of psychological safety and maturity, it is now ready to address this matter. Without point 2, however, it simply won't get off the ground.

3.4 Consider whether you're looking in the right places

Increasing levels of change-readiness does require commitment and collective action by senior leaders. However, the incentive systems in many organisations do not give adequate recognition or rewards to those in senior roles to innovate. Given this, it is no surprise that I am often told that the senior leaders operate too much in silos, don't collaborate across boundaries, and on occasions, block the sharing of resources linked to a cross-unit innovative idea. This is even more evident when resources are tight and workloads are growing. Changing the performance incentive system to encourage more cross-pollination of ideas and experiments might be worth considering.

The related challenge is to energise and encourage the voices of your mid-career leaders. The community which will be leading (whether in your organisation or elsewhere) in 2035. In my experience, they are often very likely to be both more

attuned to the realities of the culture across the organisation and more radical in their proposals for change. Creating a forum for one or more such groups to come together to share insights and create some short-term innovation groups to address questions such as: *'What sort of organisation do you want to be part of in 2035?'* , *'What needs to change to enable this to be created?'* and '*What would reduce the cultural barriers and encourage others across the university to engage?'* These questions and the answers to them can often signal the levels of change readiness within the organisation.

3.5 Have you got the right folks visibly leading your change agenda?

Too often, in many organisations I engage with, the work to create the right conditions for change-readiness is delegated to those who are highly effective project managers and organisational development specialists. These are important individuals and the best can be highly effective architects and facilitators of engaging teams in discussing the cultural dimensions of change readiness. By themselves they can, however, only go so far. The missing part is often the leadership of the areas of change through highly credible senior leaders, both those in current roles but also those who have significant credibility within and across the organisational community. These voices are critical if the wider organisation is going to understand the rationale for change, the need for a different level of readiness and preparedness for change, and the vital role which a wider community of leaders can play in the delivery process.

Where this wider community of leaders gets involved, they can be powerful advocates to create more of a 'social movement' approach to leading change. I'm a big fan of Marshall Ganz[vii] and using the power of storytelling to build the capacity and readiness for change. The process of telling the story of self, the story of us and the story of now can have a substantive impact. It does, however, demand thoughtful engagement by those who are willing to share their stories as part of the process of shifting the culture. The work by the Rippel Foundation is a useful source[viii].

3.6 Is your decision-making culture limiting your change-readiness and outcomes?

The final factor for consideration is the extent to which culture impacts on decision making. If the prevailing cultural context demands consensus for any contentious change, this is likely to impact on the level of change readiness in a number of ways. First, it is likely to reduce the willingness of some key stakeholders to step forward and engage in the delivery process. Consensual decision-making will be considered as being too politically motivated and likely to lead to compromised outcomes rather than optimal solutions. To enhance your level of change-readiness, you may need to challenge your prevailing culture to be more open to taking decisions which are not acceptable to some constituents (particularly some with 'loud' voices). Decision by committee, or committees does have its place, however not all change decisions should be taken this way. Striving for the best outcome rather than that which offends the least number of people will send a positive signal to your community about how serious you are to delivering real change and encouraging innovation.

These are merely a start point for a conversation. Which resonate with you and what else would you add?

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[i] Brighton J. 2015. Are Your Ready for Culture Change or Culture Change Readiness?.
[ii] Wiggins T. 2023. The New CEO. Wiley, 257pp.
[iii] Kennie T. and Middlehurst R. 2021. Leadership Transitions in Universities: Arriving, Surviving and Thriving. Routledge, 343pp.
[iv] Garvin D, Edmonston A. and Gino F. 2008. Is Yours a Learning Organisation. Harward Business Review, March. 2-9pp
[v] Grant A. 2023. Think Again: The Power of Knowing What You Don't. Penguin Books.
[vi] Lencioni P. 2022. Make Your Values Matter. Harvard Business Review. July.
[vii] Ganz M. 2010. Leading Change: Leadership Organisation and Social Movements. Chapter 19. Handbook of Leadership Theory and Practice: A Harvard Business School Centennial Colloquium Edited by Nitin Nohria and Rakesh Khurana
[viii] Rippel Foundation. Rethink Health. 2017. Toolkit for Developing a Public Narrative.